The Happiest Man on Earth

By Albert Maltz

Jesse felt ready to weep. He had been sitting in the shanty waiting for Tom to appear, grateful for the chance to rest his injured foot, quietly, joyously anticipating the moment when Tom would say "Why, of course, Jesse, you can start whenever you're ready!"

For two weeks he had been pushing himself, from Kansas City, Missouri to Tulsa, Oklahoma, through nights of rain and a week of scorching sun, without sleep or a decent meal, sustained by the vision of that one moment.

INTRODUCTION

During the Great Depression, millions of people were out of work across the United States. Unable to find another job locally, many unemployed people hit the road, traveling from place to place, hoping to find some work. Children also greatly suffered from malnutrition. Dietary diseases were rampant because food such as milk, fruit, fresh vegetables, and eggs could not be bought with the family's low income. So what would make a husband and father happy during this difficult time – a job of course – any job – even a dangerous one would make him The Happiest Man on Earth by Albert Matlz

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"Yes?" Tom Brackett said suddenly. "What do you want?"

"I guess you don't recognize me, Tom . . . I'm Jesse Fulton . . . and Ella sends you her love"

Brackett rose and walked over to the counter until they were face to face. He surveyed Fulton incredulously, trying to measure the resemblance to his brother-in-law as he remembered him. But the face was too gaunt, the body to spiny under the baggy clothes. It was like looking at a faded, badly taken photograph and trying to recognize the subject. "Yes, I believe you are . . . but you sure have changed."

"By God, it's been five years, ain't it?" Jessie said resentfully. Then in mingled vehemence and shame, "What if I have changed. Don't everybody? I ain't no corpse."

Brackett knew what was bothering the boy and it filled his heart with pity. The whole thing was appalling. He had never seen anyone who looked more down-and-out. "Well now, listen, tell me things. How's Ella and the kids?"

"Oh, they're fine . . . Well, you know, the young one has to wear a brace. He can't run around, you know. But he's smart. He draws pictures and he does things, you know."

"Ella didn't tell me things were so bad for you, Jesse. Damn it, boy. I can't help much. I only get thirty-five a week and I'm damn grateful for it?"

"I know you can't help us with money! But we met a man who works for you! He said you could give me a job!"

Brackett groaned aloud. "You come walking from Kansas City in two weeks so I could give you a job? You don't want to work in my department. . . . You don't know what it is."

"Yes I do . . . Egbert told me all about it, Tom. You send the dynamite trucks out for the oil business. He told me it was risky work, Tom. But I don't care. Ain't there any jobs, Tom?"

"Sure there's jobs. There's even Egbert's job if you want it."

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"He quit?"

"He's dead! On the job, Jesse. Last night if you want to know, Now you listen to me. I'll tell you a few things that you should have asked before you started out. It ain't dynamite you drive. They don't use anything as safe as dynamite in drilling oil wells. It's nitroglycerin! You just cough loud and it blows! This stuff goes only in special trucks! At night! They can't go through any city. Don't you see what that means? Don't that tell you how dangerous it is?"

"Tom, you can't scare me. I got my mind fixed on only one thing: Egbert said he was getting a dollar amile. He was making five to six hundred dollars a month for half a month's work. Can I get the same?

"Sure you can get the same. A dollar a mile. It's easy. But why to you think the company has to pay so much. It's easy - - until you run over a stone or get a blowout. We can't ask Egbert what happened to him. There's no truck to give any evidence. There's no corpse. There's nothing! Do you understand now? That's what you get for your God damn dollar a mile!"

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There was a moment of silence. Jesse sat twisting his long thin hands. His mouth was sagging open, his face was agonized. Then he shut his yes and spoke softly, "Just look at me, Tom. I just can't live like this any more. I got to be able to walk down the street with my head up.

"You're crazy . . . Every year there's one out of five drivers gets kills. That's the average. What's worth that?"

"Is my life worth anything now? We're just starvin' at home, Tom. They ain't put us back on relief yet. There ain't been other jobs for six years."

Brackett sat down with his shoulders hunched up wearily. He gripped his hands together and sat leaning forward, staring at the floor.

Jesse stood over him, his gaunt face flushed with emotion, almost unpleasant in its look of pleading and bitter humility. "I ain't done right for Ella, Tom. Ella deserved better. This is the only chance I see in my whole life to do something for her. I've just been a failure. "

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"Don't talk nonsense . . . You ain't a failure. There's millions of men in the identical situation. It's just the depression, or the recession, or the God damn New deal, or . . . !" He swore and lapsed into silence.

Jesse's face turned an unhealthy mottled red. It looked swollen. "Well I don't care! You want me to keep looking at my little boy's legs and tell myself if I had a job he wouldn't be like that? Every time he walks he says to me, 'I got soft bones from the rickets and you give it to me because you didn't feed me right.'

Brackett leaped to his feet. "You say you're thinking about Ella. How's she going to like it when you get killed? When you take this job, the only thing certain is that sooner or later you get killed."

Jessie spoke softly, passionately. "I got it all figured out. On six hundred a month look how much I can save. If I last only three months . . . that's a thousand dollars . . . more! And maybe I'll last longer. Maybe a couple years. I can fix Ella up for life!"

"Oh, shut up," Brackett said. "You think you'll be happy? Every minute, waking and sleeping, you'll be

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wondering if tomorrow you'll be dead. "

Jesse laughed. "I'll be happy! Don't you worry, I'll be so happy, I'll be singing. Lord God, Tom, I'm going to feel proud of myself for the first time in seven years!"

"Bracket sighed. "oh, God damn it," he said finally, "all right, I'll take you on, God help me." His voice was low, hoarse, infinitely weary. "If you're ready to drive tonight, you can drive tonight.

Jesse didn't answer. He couldn't. Bracket looked up. The tears were running down Jesse's face. He was swallowing and trying to speak, but only making an absurd, gasping noise. His heart felt so close to bursting that he pressed both hands against it, as though to hold it locked within his breast.

"Come back here at six o'clock." Bracket said. "Here's some money. Eat a good meal." Bracket turned away. "Oh, get out of here . . . I'm busy."

Jesse went out. The wet film blinded him, but the whole world seemed to have turned golden. He limped slowly, with the blood punding his temples and a

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wild joy in his heart. "I'm the happiest man in the world," he whispered to himself. "I'm the happiest man on the whole earth."

Bracket sat watching till finally Jesse turned the corner of the alley and disappeared. Then he hunched himself over with his head in his hands. His heart was beating painfully like something old and clogged. He listened to it as it beat. He sat in desperate tranquility, gripping his head in his hands.

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